

# The Infamous **4**:

## What made the idea of **4th**

## Instalments so disliked?

### Introduction

The infamous **4**! A homophone for **death** (in East Asian cultures)! Brought about various plagues and the burning of villages! No wonder Mista (from *JoJo's Bizarre Adventure: Golden Wind*) has tetraphobia (fear of the number **4**). It might really come with bad luck!

OK, I'm exaggerating! But some movie fanatics have been voicing their dislike of **4th** instalment of their favourite movie series. By **4th** instalments, I mean a film which is intended to continue a franchise past a completed trilogy (3-movie series). Unless the series is intended to be a tetralogy (**4**-movie series), fans dislike the idea of unnecessary **4th** instalments, fearing that its inclusion could ruin the overall series and disappoint them and critics alike.

But what are the main reasons for disliking 4th instalments? Who wouldn't want another sequel featuring characters old and new in a fresh, new adventure? I can boil them down to 3 reasons.

### Unnecessary Instalment.

Fans believe that a series continuation after a presumed complete trilogy is unnecessary, especially when it ended satisfyingly with the final movie.



An example of an unnecessary **4th** instalment, in my opinion, would be *Toy Story 4*. Despite being critically well-received, I believe that *Toy Story 3* worked a lot better as the definitive conclusion to the franchise.

*Toy Story 3* tackled topics like the transition from childhood to adulthood in its depiction of toys. In its final scene, Andy, now a college student, relives his childhood playing with Bonnie and his toys. He then decides to gift these toys to her, even his day-one best friend Woody. Woody's final line, "So long... partner", as Andy drove away, always tugs at my heartstrings (the fire pit scene still scars me greatly).

*Toy Story 4* is a good sequel, no doubt, but for its existence to be necessary for the overall story, it needed to remove the importance of the original sentimental ending. Woody's ending in the 3rd film involved him gaining a new purpose to care for Bonnie instead of being thrown away. Woody's development from having a one-sided rivalry with Buzz and fear of being replaced and not needed by Andy to being OK with leaving Andy because he understood that Andy had outgrown him. This led Woody to gain a new purpose of creating new childhood memories with Bonnie. So, to have him leave the toys group to be with Bo-peep kind of undermined the original ending for Woody's character. Now, with the upcoming announcement of *Toy Story 5*, for the movie to also work, it would have to undermine *Toy Story 4*'s ending, as it is now bringing back Woody despite him deciding to venture off from the main group.



This is the same sentiment I would've had with *Back to the Future: Part 4*, as it was rumoured to happen after its completed trilogy. Thankfully, creators shut this theory down in an interview, stating that the *Back to the Future* trilogy is a complete, perfect story that doesn't need another sequel (if it did happen, it would come off as an unnecessary cash-grab). Despite the studio's pleas, Bob Gale, one of the creators, said that any chances of there being a sequel/reboot would happen "over [their] dead body".

"People always say, 'When are you guys going to do *Back to the Future 4*?' And we say, 'F--- you.' You can quote me on this." — **Bob Gale** to [Entertainment Weekly](#)

Either way, I believe a 4th instalment can only be considered "unnecessary" if it tries to build upon the main trilogy without exploring new themes and erases important parts of previous instalments.

## Not Meeting Fan Expectations

Some **4th** instalments, even from popular franchises, may not be able to meet the high expectations of fans and critics. The **4th** movie could be so **bad** that it makes you want to

pretend that the specific instalment never existed, as if there was no war in Ba Sing Se (*Avatar: The Last Airbender* reference)... or is that just me?



One movie which I think didn't meet fan expectations and reach its full potential is *Kung Fu Panda 4*. I felt that *Kung Fu Panda 4*, while a commercial success, was a huge letdown of a sequel, to the point that I strongly dislike its entry.

After finishing the **4th** film for the first time, I remember feeling really underwhelmed as it didn't feel/act like a *Kung Fu Panda* movie. In my opinion, the movie's plot was inconsistent, short, and weak; Po's growth actually regressed, forgetting the lessons taught in *Kung Fu Panda 3* to be his own Dragon Warrior. The Chameleon, the main villain for the **4th** film, wasn't as interesting as past villains of the series, despite having unique powers/skills and potential to be a larger threat. Speaking of past villains, I disliked how their surprise inclusion was merely cameos, as they could've been great additions to the movie to cause more conflict for Po, especially when he's currently at his prime!

My largest gripe with *Kung Fu Panda 4* was the decision to exclude the Furious 5, Po's teammates who were always there in every other *Kung Fu Panda* instalment and are important to Po's growth. They were replaced with new characters who were pretty plain additions to the movie, including Zhen, Po's successor (no hate to Awkwafina). This isn't to say that the movie can't be enjoyed, but *Kung Fu Panda 4* was clearly an underbaked **4th** instalment to the series.



Because the movie did not meet fans' expectations, it is now the consensus among *Kung Fu Panda* fans that *Kung Fu Panda 4* was the weakest instalment in the franchise. Can't wait for *Kung Fu Panda 5*, though.

## Overreliance on Popular IP (Cash-Grabs)

The main reason for people's disdain for unnecessary **4th** instalments involves well-known studios being overreliant on popular media and nostalgia rather than exploring new, original ideas.

The sudden surplus of new sequels/reboots from popular IPs raises questions about whether studios are overreliant on famous franchises to the point that they're producing more instalments for profit only. People predict this as there has been a reduction in quality with each new instalment — this is either due to cost-cutting in the production process leading to factors such as duller visuals, flatter plots, poor voice acting, shorter runtimes, etc. These types of releases get labelled as “cash grabs” — a derogatory term used to describe a product as low-effort and solely produced for profit over artistic integrity.



For example, due to *Despicable Me*'s success and popularity, its franchise has become the “cash-cow” for Illumination Studios. Even when their main focus is producing repetitive comedy gags and selling merchandise, they're pretty confident that each new release will result in profit.

*Despicable Me* and *Despicable Me 2* are my favourite instalments in the franchise because of their fun, smart, and engaging stories. Especially between Gru and his family of adopted gurls, hot spy wife Lucy, scientist Dr Nefario, and thousands of yellow Minions. Both do well in balancing the humorous gags/jokes with a captivating story that both kids and adults can enjoy.

However, with later instalments and huge improvements in animation/graphics, they pushed for a more episodic-like slapstick comedy adventure with *Despicable Me 4* and the *Minions* spin-off films. Storylines became simpler while leaning heavily on comedy to maintain kids' attention. Characters, like the gurls, wouldn't have any large developments and were mostly kept in the background or in separate B/C-plots. Creators even plan on keeping their characters ageless to allow for more infinite story potential and scenarios!

Despite being less favoured than previous instalments, *Despicable Me 4* and spin-offs broke records in both box offices and merchandising. The Illumination Studios CEO and directors now plan to expand the franchise with *Despicable Me 5* and beyond, following the same approach as before until they're out of ideas. *Despicable Me* franchise is now a "cash cow" planned to be milked dry to the bone.

To be fair, if a popular IP is certain to make straight bank, even with lowered production budgets, why shouldn't they benefit from this opportunity? I'd argue that over-relying on specific franchises would make movies more repetitive and less unique. It would also drastically reduce the chances of studios picking up original ideas from new creatives.

## Conclusion

These are the three main reasons why the idea of **4th** instalments is disliked by most fans. While these are understandable criticisms, subjective opinions mostly carry them and can heavily influence someone's thoughts on a film.

Either way, these criticisms can be made for any kind of sequel, like *Megamind 2: The Doom Syndicate* (may god rest all those souls who willingly watched that film). But not all **4th** instalments, either as sequels, reboots, or remakes, are inherently bad films, like *Mad Max* with *Mad Max: Fury Road* and *Furiosa*, despite not having all the same actors as before.

I believe the main takeaway is that it's not wrong to continue a series past its trilogy, even a decade later, if it actually adds to the series' main story and doesn't undermine it. However, as we're heading into a new generation, it's now more important for large Hollywood industries to allow opportunities for young creatives to make, fail, and succeed with new, original franchises. This is to get surprise movie hits like *Obsession*, *The Backrooms*, and indie powerhouses such as *The Amazing Digital Circus*.

But hey, good thing that REELHOUSE magazine is exempt from this **4th instalment curse**. Thank god.

